

A VISIBILITY PLAN FOR YOUR BRAND

AI SEO · AEO · GEO

Get found where buyers search, and where **AI** answers.

The complete Answer Engine Optimization course — how to earn traffic and brand visibility from AI search.

STRUCTURE · Intro + 4 modules · 11 lessons

RUNTIME · ~87 MIN

FOCUS · Execution-first playbook

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Welcome to the Answer Engine Optimization (AEO) course. The goal is simple: teach you how to earn traffic **and** brand visibility from AI search — ChatGPT, Google's AI Overviews, Perplexity, Gemini, Copilot and Google's AI Mode.

The course is heavily execution-focused. If you have an SEO background you already have a huge head start, because **SEO is the foundation of AEO**. Every number in this deck is backed by original industry research — including a 75,000-brand correlation study and an analysis of 55.8M AI Overviews (source: Ahrefs research).

Search is shifting under your feet.

–58%

CTR to the #1 result when an AI Overview is present (Dec 2025)

900M

Weekly ChatGPT users – ~12% of Google's search volume

9.7×

Growth in AI referral traffic to websites in the past year

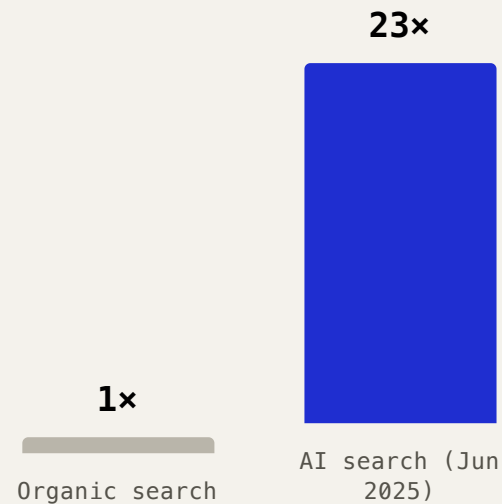
For every 100 clicks you used to get, Google now keeps 58 inside the answer.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Here's the urgency. As of December 2025, an AI Overview on the results page cuts the #1 listing's click-through rate by **58%** — for every 100 clicks you used to get, Google keeps 58 inside the answer.

Meanwhile ChatGPT alone has ~900 million weekly users and handles about 12% of Google's search volume, and AI traffic to websites has grown 9.7× in a year. Ignore the shift and watch traffic shrink — or learn how it works and capitalize.

Small traffic, outsized value.



RELATIVE SIGNUP CONVERSION RATE — AI VS ORGANIC (SOURCE: AHREFS RESEARCH)

In one company's data, AI search was just **0.5%** of traffic but drove **12.1%** of signups. When AI recommends you, it has already sold the user — so the visitor arrives pre-qualified.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Search is no longer just about clicks. In one dataset from June 2025, AI search was only 0.5% of total traffic but accounted for 12.1% of signups — a **23× higher conversion rate than organic**.

The reason: when AI recommends you, it has already told the user why you're a good fit, so the traffic arrives pre-qualified. Low volume, exceptional quality — that's the AEO opportunity.

What is Answer Engine Optimization?

Making your content **visible and useful to AI systems that deliver direct answers** — any platform where AI generates a response and chooses who to cite.

Where it applies

- Google AI Overviews & AI Mode
- ChatGPT · Perplexity
- Gemini · Copilot

Also known as

- **GEO** — Generative Engine Optimization
- **LLMO** — Large Language Model Optimization
- Same idea — we use **AEO**

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

AEO means making your content visible and useful to AI systems that deliver direct answers — Google AI Overviews, ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini, Copilot and any platform where AI generates a response and decides who to cite.

You'll hear the same idea called **GEO** (Generative Engine Optimization) or **LLMO** (Large Language Model Optimization). They mean essentially the same thing; this course uses AEO throughout.

You compete for a mention, not a position.

	TRADITIONAL SEO	AEO
The surface	A ranked list of blue links	One synthesized answer — no list
You win by	Ranking in a position	Earning a mention / citation
The path	See link → click → land on site	AI reads dozens of sources, decides who to name
The rules	Ranking factors	Overlapping but different — consensus, freshness, entities

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

In traditional SEO you optimize a page to rank higher in a list of blue links and compete for positions. In AEO there is no list — the AI reads from many sources, synthesizes an answer, and decides who to mention or cite.

So you're competing for a **mention**, not a ranking position, and the rules for getting mentioned differ from the rules for ranking. Module 1 breaks down exactly how that works.

AEO builds on SEO — it doesn't replace it.

- **SEO is the foundation; AEO future-proofs it.** Quality content, authority and technical health still matter.
- **Beware the zero-sum bias** (Ethan Smith, Graphite) — assuming something new rising means something old must fall.
- **2010 app-store analogy:** "mobile apps will kill the web." Apps boomed — and the web grew alongside them.
- **Proof it compounds:** one well-optimized site was mentioned **7,470 times across 2,390 pages** in AI search with **zero** AEO effort — just solid SEO (source: Ahrefs research).

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

This is not the end of SEO. The "AI will kill SEO" instinct is the **zero-sum bias** — the assumption that if something new rises, something old must fall. In 2010 people said mobile apps would kill the web; apps boomed and the web grew alongside them. AI search is likely the same story.

Proof it compounds from good SEO: one company's pages were mentioned 7,470 times across 2,390 pages in AI search **without any optimization for it** — purely from solid SEO and useful content. Imagine the upside once you optimize intentionally.

The course.

1

How AI search works — finding & citing, platform differences, what "AI visibility" really looks like.

2

Strategy — why brand mentions are the strongest lever; brand gap analysis; keyword & prompt research.

3

Execution — content that gets cited, earning mentions, YouTube optimization, technical fixes.

4

Measurement — AI analytics, competitive audits, ROI, and a concrete action plan.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Here's the lay of the land. **Module 1** is the foundation — the mechanics that make every later tactic make sense. **Module 2** is strategy: assess where you stand, then discover the keywords and prompts to target. **Module 3** is execution — the actual work. **Module 4** is measurement, ROI and your action plan.

By the end you'll have a bespoke, do-it-this-week plan, with a repeatable workflow for each step.

MODULE ONE

How AI Search Actually Works.

Three things you must understand: where AI gets information, how it expands your query, and how it decides who to cite. Get this and every tactic clicks into place.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Module 1 covers the mechanics of how AI search engines find, evaluate and cite content. Without the "why," every optimization tip feels like a random list of tactics. With it, the whole course becomes coherent.

AI has two sources of information.

SOURCE 1

Training data

- The huge corpus the model learned from — books, sites, PDFs, social, YouTube transcripts
- Instant recall ("CEO of Apple → Tim Cook")
- **Static** — refreshed ~every 6 months; won't know last week's launch

SOURCE 2

Real-time retrieval (RAG)

- When info is fresh or very specific, AI searches the web via APIs
- Pulls pages, reads them, then generates the answer
- Each retrieved page carries its own probability

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

This distinction is the most important thing to understand. **Training data** is the static snapshot the model learned from — great for known facts, but updated only every six months or so, so it won't know something you launched last week.

Real-time retrieval — retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) — is the second process: when the question needs fresh or very specific information, the AI fetches relevant pages from the web and generates its answer from them. These are the two doors through which your content reaches the model.

Two ways to influence what AI says about you.

1 · Get into the training data

- Be mentioned so **widely and consistently** across the web that you're baked into the model itself

2 · Win the real-time retrieval

- Make sure your content **shows up when AI searches live**
- This is **SEO** — ranking, backlinks and quality content decide what AI retrieves

Your existing SEO skills map directly onto real-time retrieval.

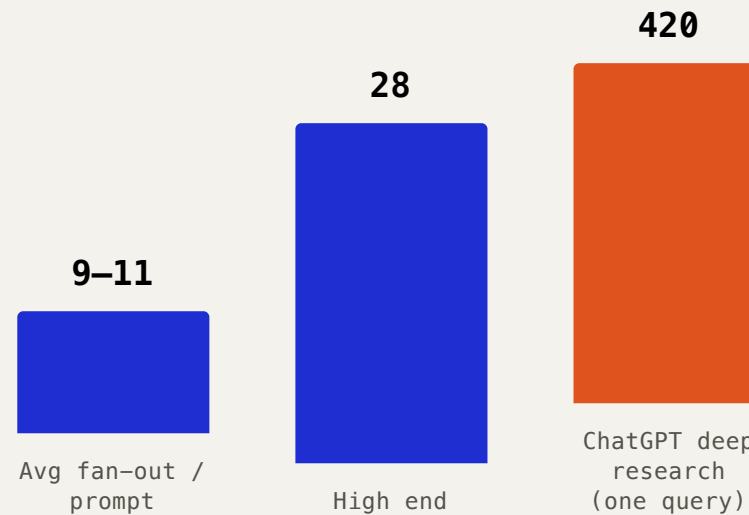
■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Because there are two sources, there are two levers. First, be mentioned widely and consistently enough that your brand is baked into the **training data**. Second, make sure your pages surface during **real-time retrieval**.

The second lever is just SEO — ranking in Google, earning backlinks, creating quality content all directly influence whether AI picks up your pages when it searches live. Your existing SEO skills transfer straight over.

Query fan-out: one search becomes many.

Search went one-to-one → many-to-one → AI's **one-to-many**. A single prompt is fanned into dozens of sub-queries, run at once.



"PLAN A 5-DAY JAPAN TRIP" → TOKYO NEIGHBORHOODS · KYOTO WEATHER · IS THE JR PASS WORTH IT?

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Older search was one-to-one, then many-to-one (different phrasings → same results). AI flips it to **one-to-many**: it fans a single prompt into dozens of sub-queries, runs them simultaneously, pulls from many sources, and merges everything into one answer.

Research (Seer Interactive) found an average of 9–11 fan-out queries per prompt, some as high as 28, and ChatGPT's deep-research mode ran 420 searches for a single red-phone-case query. The lesson: be relevant across an entire topic — even a niche — not just one keyword. A thin page that ignores subtopics loses to one that covers them.

Use fan-out as a lens, not a keyword list.

- **You can see them** — AI brand-visibility tools expose an "AI responses" report showing fan-out queries for ChatGPT & Perplexity.
- **They're synthetic** — generated in the moment, not real searches.
- **Inconsistent** — the same prompt triggers different fan-outs each time.
- **Over 95% have zero search volume** — no human would ever type them.
- **So treat them as a window** into the subtopics AI thinks matter for a question.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

You can inspect fan-out queries in an AI brand-visibility tool's "AI responses" report for ChatGPT and Perplexity. But heed this caveat: these are **synthetic** — invented in the moment, inconsistent between runs, and 95%+ have zero search volume because no real person would type them.

Don't mistake them for a keyword list to optimize one-by-one. They're a **window into which subtopics the AI considers important** — which tells you what your topical coverage needs to include.

AI citations are probabilistic, not fixed.

"AI outputs are built on probabilities on top of probabilities on top of probabilities." — Patrick Stox

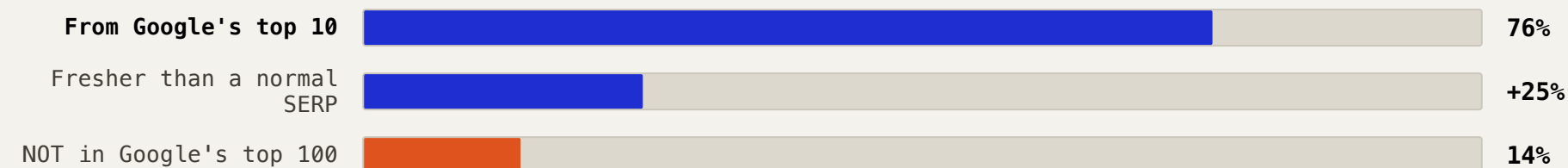
- **Training data** creates patterns → **retrieved pages** add signals → a **temperature** setting adds randomness.
- Ask the same question 5× and you might be cited 3 of 5 times.
- There's no fixed slot — think **AI visibility** (a probability distribution), not a leaderboard.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Unlike stable search rankings, AI citations are probabilistic. Patrick Stox describes it as probabilities stacked on probabilities: training data forms patterns, retrieved pages add their own signals, and a temperature setting injects randomness so answers vary.

In practice, the same question asked five times may cite you three times, or mix you with competitors. That's why we talk about **AI visibility** — a probability distribution — rather than a fixed ranking.

What raises your citation odds.



SHARE OF AI-OVERVIEW CITATIONS BY SOURCE · CONSENSUS + FRESHNESS + AUTHORITY

Consensus · repeated, consistent mentions raise probability — but authority isn't only Google: 14% of cited pages don't rank top-100 at all.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

There are clear patterns. **Consensus**: repeated, consistent mentions across the web raise your probability. **Freshness**: AI-cited content runs ~25% fresher than a normal SERP. **Authority**: 76% of AI Overview citations come from pages already in Google's top 10 — so SEO is the foundation, again.

Crucially it's not only about Google: 14% of AI-Overview-cited pages don't rank in Google's top 100 at all, and for platforms like ChatGPT the overlap is even lower. Brands weak in traditional search can still win in AI.

The mechanics, tied together.

- A** AI pulls from **training data** + **real-time web search**.
- B** **Fan-out** expands one query into dozens of sub-queries.
- C** It **merges and scores** results from all of them.
- D** It generates a **probabilistic** answer — patterns, consensus, freshness, authority.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Putting it together: AI search pulls from training data and live web search, expands your query through fan-out, merges and scores the results, then generates a probabilistic answer shaped by patterns, consensus, freshness and authority.

This is why "earn more brand mentions" (consensus), "cover the whole topic" (fan-out) and "SEO first" (76% from top-10 pages) are the throughlines of everything that follows.

AI search is not one thing.

14%

Overlap of the top-50 most-cited domains across AIO, ChatGPT & Perplexity – only 7 of 50 on all three

13.7%

Citation overlap between Google's own AI Overviews & AI Mode

86%

...yet their answers are 86% semantically similar – same message, different sources

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Treating AI search as one channel leaves visibility on the table. Of the top-50 most-cited domains across AI Overviews, ChatGPT and Perplexity, only 7 appear on all three — a 14% overlap. Optimize for one platform and you can be invisible on the others.

Even two Google products diverge: AI Overviews and AI Mode share only 13.7% of citations despite 86% semantically similar answers — same message, completely different sources.

What each platform prefers to cite.

PLATFORM	LEANS TOWARD	SIGNATURE STAT
AI Overviews	Authoritative & Google-owned sources	YouTube ≈ 5.6% of all citations; Reddit heavy
ChatGPT	High-authority publishers & media	Median DR of top pages = 90
Perplexity	Closest to classic Google search	28.6% of citations from Google's top 10
Google AI Mode	Video & social	YouTube #1; cites Quora 3.5x more than AIO

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Each platform has its own index and biases. **AI Overviews** favor authoritative, established and Google-owned sources — YouTube alone is ~5.6% of citations, and Reddit features heavily. **ChatGPT** leans on high-authority publishers (median domain rating 90), partly from OpenAI's licensing deals, and overlaps Google's top 10 only 8–10% of the time.

Perplexity is closest to classic Google — 28.6% of its citations come from Google's top 10, the fastest win if you already rank. **AI Mode** is dominated by YouTube and leans on Quora and social more than AI Overviews.

Which platform should you focus on?

- **Market share:** Google's AI features + ChatGPT hold most AI-search volume today — prioritize **Google + ChatGPT**.
- **SEO overlap:** already ranking? You have a head start with AI Overviews & Perplexity — lean in.
- **The link is weakening:** "76% of AIO citations from Google's top 10" has dropped to ~**38%** as AIO pulls more from YouTube & Reddit.
- **ChatGPT rewards off-site authority:** a Forbes feature or Reddit thread can matter more than your page's ranking.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Be strategic rather than optimizing for everything. Two factors: **market share** (Google + ChatGPT dominate volume) and **overlap with your existing SEO** (strong Google rankings help AI Overviews and Perplexity).

The connection is weakening — the share of AIO citations from Google's top 10 fell from ~76% to ~38% as AIO pulls more from YouTube and Reddit. And for ChatGPT, third-party authority (Forbes, Reddit, niche reviews) can matter more than your own ranking. Many top AI-cited domains get little traditional traffic — AI visibility is its own game. Inspect top domains per platform in an AI brand-visibility tool's cited-domains report.

Winning comes in three forms.

BEST CASE

1 · Cited & linked

- AI links to your page
- Direct traffic; easiest to measure

2 · Mentioned, not linked

- Named but not linked
- Word-of-mouth at scale — users search for you next

BLIND SPOT

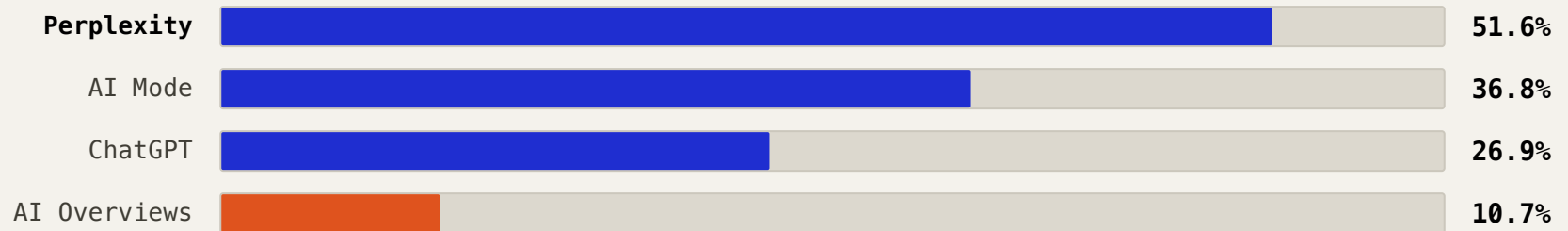
3 · Not visible

- Out of the conversation
- Can't fix what you can't see

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Most people think AI visibility means one thing — a clickable link. It's actually a spectrum. **Cited & linked** is the direct-traffic best case. **Mentioned but not linked** gives no click, but the user now knows your name and will often search for you — word-of-mouth at scale. **Not visible** means you're out of the conversation, which matters because you can't fix a gap you can't see.

Only ~28% of mentions include a link.



SHARE OF BRAND MENTIONS THAT INCLUDE A LINK, BY PLATFORM

~7 of 10 times your brand appears in an AI answer, there's no link attached.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

On average only ~28% of AI mentions include a link — about 7 in 10 times your brand appears, there's no link. It varies widely: Perplexity 51.6%, AI Mode 36.8%, ChatGPT 26.9%, AI Overviews just 10.7%. If you mainly track AI Overviews, nearly 9 of 10 mentions are link-free.

But links cluster on the biggest queries.

PLATFORM	IN % OF MENTIONS	IN % OF IMPRESSIONS (VOLUME-WEIGHTED)
Perplexity	51%	78%
Gemini	16.8%	71%

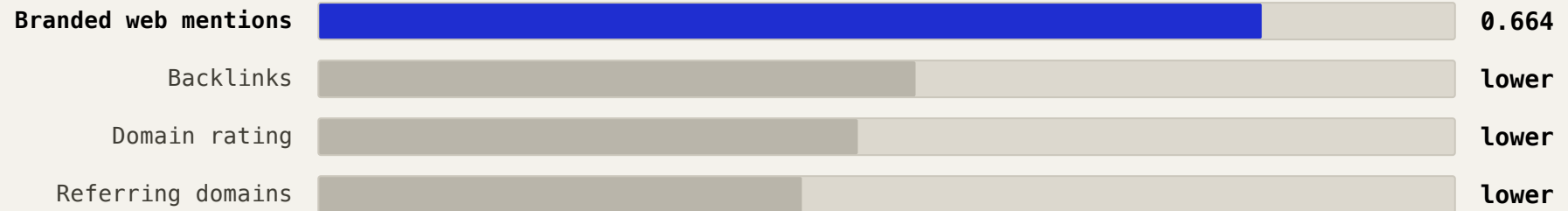
WEIGHTING MENTIONS BY SEARCH VOLUME SHOWS LINKS LAND WHERE THE EYEBALLS ARE

Citations are rare – but when they happen, they happen on the highest-traffic queries.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

When you weight by search volume, the linked mentions land on the **highest-traffic queries**: on Perplexity links appear in 78% of impressions despite only 51% of mentions; on Gemini, 71% of impressions vs 16.8% of mentions. Citations are rare, but they happen where the most eyeballs are.

Unlinked mentions are the strongest lever.



CORRELATION WITH AI-OVERVIEW VISIBILITY · 75,000-BRAND STUDY (SOURCE: AHREFS RESEARCH)

LLMs learn associations ("peanut butter → jelly"). Every credible mention is another training example — it compounds.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Unlinked mentions are far from worthless. LLMs learn by reading the web, so every time your brand appears on a credible page tied to a topic, it's another training example — and repeated association ("peanut butter → jelly," "Tesla → electric cars") makes the model mention you more confidently.

A 75,000-brand study found **branded web mentions had the strongest correlation with AI visibility of any factor — 0.664** with AI Overviews, beating backlinks, domain rating and referring domains. Even unlinked, being mentioned is the long game, and it compounds.

Response type decides what matters for you.

Step-by-step guides

- "How to fix a leaky faucet"
- Great for service & how-to brands to be the recommended expert

Direct answers

- "Capital of France?"
- Builds authority for publishers — rarely a click

Video citations

- YouTube among the most-cited domains
- Creators' videos surface directly

In an AI brand-visibility tool, the gap between your **impressions** and your **mentions** is your opportunity.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Not all AI responses look the same, and the type that matters depends on your business. **Step-by-step** queries suit service businesses and how-to creators who want to be recommended as the expert. **Direct-answer** queries build authority for publishers but rarely earn a click. **Video citations** favor creators, since YouTube is one of the most-cited domains.

To see where you stand, search your site in an AI brand-visibility tool and filter by mentions, citations, impressions and share of voice. The gap between impressions and mentions is exactly where to focus — the subject of Module 2.

MODULE TWO

Strategy: Research, Targeting & Gaps.

Two phases: **Assess** where your brand stands today with a brand gap analysis, then **Discover** the keywords and prompts people actually use to find businesses like yours.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Module 2 turns mechanics into strategy in two phases. First **assess** — run a brand gap analysis to find exactly where you're missing. Then **discover** — build the keyword and prompt lists worth targeting. The audit you produce here becomes your personalized roadmap for the rest of the course.

Map your branded entities first.

A brand gap analysis measures the difference between where your brand *should* show up and where it *actually* does — across Google, AI results and the wider web.

Map every way you're referred to

- Main brand · sub-brands · product names
- Proprietary features & metrics
- Associated personal brands
- e.g. your flagship product, a proprietary metric, a founder's personal brand...

Connect each to topics/attributes

- LLMs infer meaning from how you're described
- Use keyword research for recurring modifiers — "affordable", "AI-powered", "enterprise-grade"
- This becomes your benchmark

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Before finding gaps, get clear on what you're measuring. Map every way your brand is referred to: the main name, sub-brands, product names, proprietary features and metrics, and associated personal brands — each has its own visibility profile.

Then connect each entity to the topics and attributes people should associate with it. Search engines and LLMs infer meaning from how you're described, so use keyword research to surface the recurring adjectives and modifiers (affordable, AI-powered, enterprise-grade) that define what you should be found for.

Run the audit.

METRIC	WHAT IT MEANS
SEO baseline	Domain authority, referring domains, organic keywords, traffic & value
Mentions	Times your brand is named in AI responses
Citations	Times your site is cited as a source
Impressions	Estimated exposure of responses containing your brand
AI Share of Voice	How often you're mentioned vs competitors

The power is in the filters: brand-mentioned-but-not-cited · competitor-mentioned-but-not-you · per-topic association.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Start with your traditional SEO baseline — domain authority, referring domains, organic keywords, traffic and traffic value. Then look at the AI citation metrics in an AI brand-visibility tool, where the real audit happens.

Track four things: mentions (times named), citations (times your site is the source), impressions (estimated exposure) and AI share of voice (vs competitors). The real power is in the filters — isolate prompts that mention you but don't cite you, queries where a competitor appears but you don't, and specific topics to see who AI associates them with.

Identify gaps across six dimensions.

GAP	WHAT IT REVEALS
Visibility	You appear less often than competitors
Narrative	AI describes you wrong (e.g. “budget” when you’re premium)
Topic	Topics you should own but aren’t linked to
Format	Missing the content types AI cites (guides, video, comparisons)
Web mentions	Listicles / forums cite rivals, not you
Demand	Awareness searches where your name never comes up

FRAMEWORK: BUCKET YOUR PROMPTS INTO THESE SIX DIMENSIONS

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

One useful framework groups brand gaps into six dimensions. **Visibility**: you appear less than competitors. **Narrative**: AI mis-positions you. **Topic**: subjects you should own but aren't associated with. **Format**: you don't produce the content types AI cites. **Web mentions**: third-party pages list competitors but not you — one of the strongest AI signals. **Demand**: awareness-stage searches where your name never surfaces.

Together these give a complete picture — not just how often you show up, but whether you show up for the right things, in the right way, in the right places. Bucket your prompts into these six as you audit.

Prioritize: Fix, Build, or Influence.

Fix

- Improve what exists
- Update a ranking page to close a topic gap — low effort, high impact

Build

- Create new content/pages for uncovered opportunities

Influence

- Strengthen off-site visibility via outreach & mentions
- Get onto a listicle all rivals are on

Weigh each by: demand · brand credibility · citation likelihood. Start with quick wins. Repeat the whole audit for competitors.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

You'll find more gaps than you can fix at once, so prioritize into three actions: **Fix** (optimize what exists — often the fastest win), **Build** (create new content) and **Influence** (earn off-site mentions).

Weigh each opportunity by potential demand, brand credibility and citation likelihood, and start with the quick ones. Then run the exact same audit on competitors to uncover topics and branded queries users connect to them more than you. A simple shared spreadsheet template works well to organize this and share with stakeholders.

Research for AEO: same list, different lens.

- 1 Build your list** — seeds + modifiers (ask AI for 10 seeds & 5+ modifiers), expand using a keyword research tool's matching-terms report.
- 2 Vet with BID** — Business potential, Intent, Difficulty.
- 3 Apply the AI filter** — can AI fully satisfy this query alone?
- 4 Find AI mention opportunities** — where AI names rivals, not you.
- 5 Prompt research** — natural-language, conversational queries.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Keyword research for AEO overlaps heavily with SEO — half the battle is telling which opportunities are SEO and which are AEO. **Step 1:** build a list from seeds and modifiers (a quick prompt to your AI assistant produces 10 seeds and 5+ modifiers; expand via a keyword research tool's matching-terms report).

The next slides cover vetting with BID, the AI filter, finding mention opportunities and prompt research.

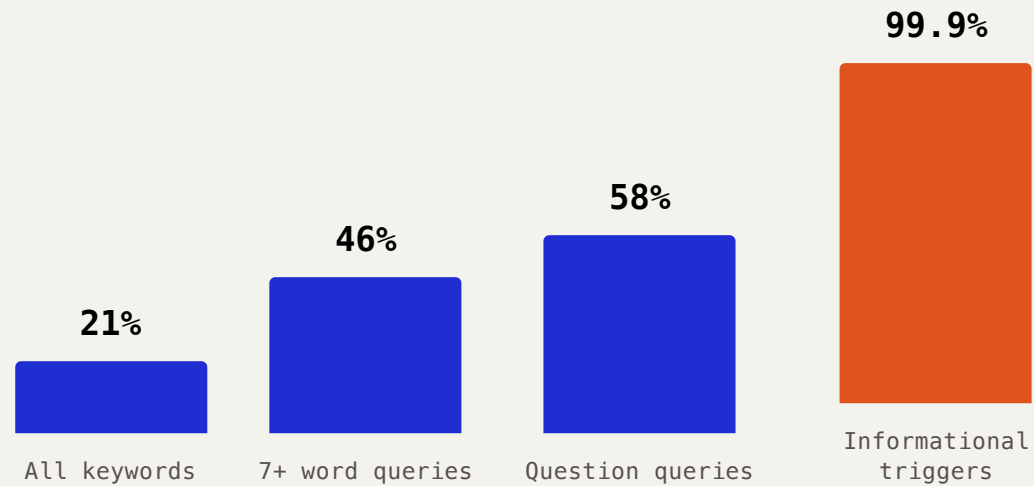
Is a keyword worth targeting?

TEST	ASK	EXAMPLE
B · Business potential	If I rank #1, does it help the business?	“best espresso machine under \$500” > “what is espresso”
I · Intent	Does the SERP match my content type?	E-commerce SERP + a blog post = mismatch
D · Difficulty	Can I realistically rank?	A few low-DR sites in the top 10 = an opening

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Some tempting keywords are traps. Before committing, run **BID**. **Business potential**: ranking #1 should actually help the business. **Intent**: Google the term and match your content type to what ranks; if every result is an e-commerce page, a blog post won't win. **Difficulty**: check referring domains and DR of the top pages — a few low-DR sites signal an opening.

Can AI fully satisfy the query alone?



HOW OFTEN AI OVERVIEWS APPEAR, BY QUERY TYPE

Queries AI **can't** satisfy stay open: **calculator** · **checker** · **generator** · **tool** · **template** · **finder** · **planner** · **maker**, or filter for transactional intent.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Even a BID-passing keyword can be a trap if the AI Overview answers it so well that no one clicks. AI Overviews show on ~21% of all keywords, but ~58% of question queries, 46% of 7+ word queries, and 99.9% of AIO-triggering keywords are informational. Google the term and ask: am I satisfied, or do I need to click?

The good news is a whole category AI hasn't touched — **tools and action queries**. Add modifiers like calculator, checker, generator, tool, template, finder, planner, maker, or filter for transactional intent. When someone needs to *do* something, the organic click is still there.

Find mention opportunities, then research prompts.

4 · AI mention opportunities

- **43.8%** of AI-cited pages are listicles (they build consensus)
- In an AI brand-tracking tool: hover the platform → "others only" = mention gaps
- Filter for **best · top · versus · review · alternative**
- ~45% of AIO citations change on refresh (~every 2 days)

5 · Prompt research

- People converse — they don't type keywords
- Same question 10 ways → 10 answers, 10 brand sets
- Each prompt fans out into zero-volume sub-queries
- Goal: visibility across the whole **topic**

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Step 4: if AI nails the answer, aim to be mentioned in the response. 43.8% of AI-cited pages are listicles (being on multiple lists compounds). In an AI brand-visibility tool, enter your site, hover the platform and click "others only" to reveal mention gaps, then filter for best/top/versus/review/alternative — that's your short-list. Because ~45% of AIO citations change on each refresh (about every two days), revisit regularly.

Step 5: on ChatGPT, AI Mode and Perplexity people converse, not keyword-search. The same question phrased ten ways yields different brands, and every prompt fans out into zero-volume sub-queries. So you build visibility across the entire topic — which Module 3 delivers.

MODULE THREE

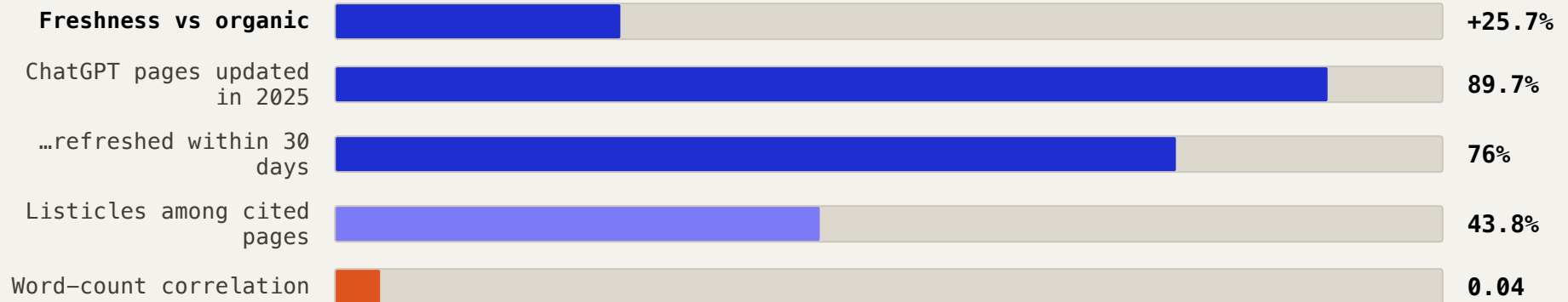
Execution: Do the Work.

Four lessons of hands-on tactics — create content that gets cited, earn mentions on the pages AI already pulls from, optimize YouTube for AI, and clear the technical blockers.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Module 3 is where the work happens: creating content that gets cited, earning third-party mentions, optimizing YouTube for AI visibility (which most courses skip), and fixing the technical issues that stop AI from crawling you.

What AI actually cites — the data.



LENGTH ≈ ZERO. FRESHNESS & FORMAT WIN. (53.4% OF CITED PAGES ARE UNDER 1,000 WORDS)

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Three data-backed truths. **Length is irrelevant** — across 174,000+ cited pages the correlation between word count and citation is 0.04, and 53.4% of cited pages are under 1,000 words.

Freshness is powerful — AI-cited content is 25.7% fresher than organic; 89.7% of ChatGPT's top-cited pages were updated in 2025 and 76% within the last 30 days. Make *meaningful* updates though — Google detects a bare date change. **Format matters** — 43.8% of ChatGPT citations are listicles, and data-driven stats and comparisons perform well because they map to how people ask AI.

Structure content with four principles.

BLUF · Bottom Line Up Front

- Start each section with the answer
- Humans scan in an F-pattern; LLMs weight the start & end most

Atomic content

- Every section stands alone
- AI chunks unpredictably — self-contained sections survive any boundary

Entity-rich writing

- Name brands, products, people, concepts
- "[Your Product]'s keyword report finds low-difficulty terms" > "this tool helps with SEO"

Simple & declarative

- Short sentences, one idea each
- Easier for people *and* AI to parse

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

You don't write differently "for AI" — AI is trained on what humans find valuable, so content that serves readers well is content AI wants to cite.

BLUF: lead each section with the answer; humans scan in an F-pattern and LLMs weight the beginning and end of a passage most. **Atomic content:** make every section self-contained, because AI chunks your page unpredictably (test: read an H2 out of context — does it still make sense?).

Entity-rich writing: name specific brands, products, people and concepts. **Simple and declarative:** short sentences, one idea each — easy to parse and extract.

Brand your ideas · refresh sleeper pages.

Label ideas with your brand

- LLMs **flatten originality** — they absorb frameworks without credit
- Name it: "the [Your Brand] Content Scoring Matrix," define it explicitly
- Distribute widely — blog, social, podcasts, Reddit

Refresh "sleeper" pages

- Once ranked, slowly declined — still hold backlinks & authority
- Your SEO tool's top-pages report → sort by traffic change
- Confirm it's a **content** issue, not a links issue, then update

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Two more levers. First, **label your ideas with your brand**: LLMs flatten original concepts into generic knowledge, so name your framework, define it explicitly, and distribute it everywhere — the more places it appears with your name, the harder it is to flatten.

Second, **refresh sleeper pages** — pages that once ranked and declined. They still hold backlinks and authority; they just need a real update, and since freshness drives AI citations this is one of the fastest wins. Find them in your SEO tool's top-pages report, sort by traffic change, and confirm the decline is a content problem before updating.

Earn mentions in three tiers.

Where you're mentioned matters as much as how often — mentions on **highly-linked pages** correlate **0.7** with AI-Overview visibility.

TIER	SOURCES	WHY IT MATTERS
1 • Editorial	Publications, review sites, authoritative listicles, creator reviews	Hardest to earn, most valuable — exactly what AI cites
2 • Community / UGC	Reddit, Quora, niche forums	Reddit is heavily cited & a core LLM training source
3 • Own properties	Your YouTube, podcast, LinkedIn	All indexed — all potential AI sources

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Much of AEO is off-site. Branded web mentions had the strongest correlation with AI Overview visibility, and mentions on **highly-linked pages** correlate 0.7 — quality of page matters as much as frequency.

Tier 1 editorial mentions are hardest to earn but most valuable — exactly the pages AI loves (43.8% of ChatGPT citations are listicles/comparisons).

Tier 2 community sources matter more than people think — Reddit is heavily cited and a foundational training source; contribute real answers, never spam. **Tier 3** is your own properties — YouTube, podcast, LinkedIn — all indexed and all potential AI sources.

Find the pages — and watch your mentions.

Find target pages

- AI brand-tracking tool → **cited domains** report (which sites AI cites for your topics)
- Target already-linked pages before they're cited
- Content-search tool: **title:best** / **title:versus** + **-yourbrand**
- Reddit: your SEO tool → reddit.com → organic keywords report

Audit mentions regularly

- Mentions vanish when lists refresh
- Track mention trends & drops
- Check **sentiment** & accuracy
- Misinfo? Fix your content first, then request a correction

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

To find where to earn mentions, open an AI brand-visibility tool's cited-domains report to see the sites AI cites for your topics. You don't have to wait for a page to be cited — target already-linked pages that cover your topic. A content-search tool helps: search **title:best** or **title:versus** with a minus operator before your brand to surface listicles you're missing. For Reddit, run reddit.com through your SEO tool's organic keywords report, filter to top-5 rankings plus your niche.

Then audit continuously — mentions vanish when lists refresh, and AI can pick up wrong info. Track mention trends, watch for drops, and check sentiment/accuracy. If you spot misinformation, fix your own content first, then ask the publisher to correct theirs.

YouTube: the single strongest AI lever.



CORRELATION STRENGTHS · YOUTUBE WAS THE STRONGEST FACTOR IN THIS RESEARCH (SOURCE: AHREFS)

#1 most-cited domain in AI Overviews · GPT-4 trained on **1M+ hours** of YouTube transcripts – AI learns from YouTube, not just cites it.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

YouTube deserves its own lesson. It's the most-cited domain in Google's AI Overviews, YouTube mentions have a 0.737 correlation with ChatGPT visibility — the strongest of any factor studied — and GPT-4 was trained on over a million hours of YouTube transcripts. So YouTube is a platform AI both cites and learns from.

The process is three steps: find what already works (search hits), create videos engineered to rank, then layer in AI visibility.

Target search hits, then optimize to rank.

1 · Find search hits (not viral)

- Consistent monthly traffic; viral spikes then dies
- If Google ranks a video, AIO likely cites it too
- Your SEO tool: **youtube.com/watch** → organic keywords → top-3 + niche

2 · The ranking checklist

- Keyword **in the title** (save creativity for the thumbnail)
- Description = real summary, keyword up top
- Add **timestamps** → chapters can rank in Google
- **Say the keyword** aloud — Google understands audio
- Match the format that already ranks

3 · Layer AI visibility: in an AI brand-tracking tool's topics report, filter domain = youtube.com to see which queries pull YouTube in — then make those videos.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Step 1 — target search hits, not viral hits. Viral videos spike then die; search hits earn steady Google + YouTube traffic and are what AI pulls from (if Google already ranks a video, AI Overviews likely cite it). Find them in your SEO tool: enter youtube.com/watch, open the organic keywords report, filter to top-3 plus your niche.

Step 2 — the ranking checklist: keyword in the title, a real summary description with the keyword up top, timestamps (they become chapters that can rank in Google), actually say the keyword aloud since Google understands audio, and match the format already ranking. **Step 3 — layer AI visibility:** in an AI brand-tracking tool's topics report, filter the mentioned domain to youtube.com to see which queries pull YouTube in, then create for those topics. Every video is also potential training data.

Make sure AI can access you.

5.9% of 140M websites block GPTBot — millions invisible to ChatGPT, often unintentionally.

CRAWLER	OWNER	ALLOW IT
GPTBot · OAI-SearchBot	OpenAI	Yes
ClaudeBot	Anthropic	Yes
Google-Extended	Google	Yes

Check `yourdomain.com/robots.txt`. Cloudflare's "block AI bot traffic" is **on by default**. `llms.txt`: proposed, no major LLM uses it yet — don't prioritize.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

A lot of sites accidentally block AI: 5.9% of 140M websites block GPTBot, so they're invisible to ChatGPT. `robots.txt` tells crawlers what they can access — allow GPTBot and OAI-SearchBot (OpenAI), ClaudeBot (Anthropic) and Google-Extended (Google). Blocks often creep in from templates or platforms — notably Cloudflare's "block AI bot traffic" feature is enabled by default and edits your `robots.txt`.

Check `yourdomain.com/robots.txt` for disallow rules on those bots, or run a technical SEO audit tool, which flags them. As for `llms.txt` — a proposed `robots.txt`-style file — no major provider officially reads it yet, so it won't hurt but shouldn't be a priority.

Five more technical checks.

- **JavaScript rendering:** Gemini & Copilot render JS; **ChatGPT's crawler does not**. Fix JS-dependent pages with **server-side rendering** (test: disable JS, load your page).
- **Page speed:** matters *more* for AI — slow pages get dropped before scoring during real-time retrieval.
- **Clean HTML:** proper H1→H2→H3, each section self-contained & parseable.
- **Schema markup:** evidence mixed — keep it if you use it for SEO; don't over-invest.
- **Hallucinated URLs:** AI sends visitors to 404s **2.87×** more than Google (ChatGPT ~1% of clicks) — find them in analytics and **redirect**.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Five checks. **JavaScript:** Gemini and Copilot render JS but ChatGPT's crawler doesn't, so JS-dependent SPAs look empty to it — server-side rendering fixes this; test by disabling JS. **Page speed:** matters more for AI because real-time retrieval fetches, parses and chunks on the fly, and slow pages get dropped before scoring. **Clean HTML:** logical H1→H2→H3 hierarchy with self-contained sections makes content parseable.

Schema markup: evidence for AEO is mixed — keep it if you already use it for SEO but don't over-invest. **Hallucinated URLs:** AI assistants send visitors to 404s 2.87× more often than Google (ChatGPT ~1% of clicked URLs); find AI-referred 404s in analytics and redirect consistent ones to the closest real page.

MODULE FOUR

Measurement, ROI & Action Plan.

AI visibility is harder to measure than SEO — but you're not flying blind. Three tracking pillars, a progress framework, the real ROI case, and a plan you can start this week.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Execution means nothing if you can't tell it's working — but AI visibility is harder to measure than SEO. Module 4 gives you three tracking pillars, a way to judge progress, the ROI argument, and a step-by-step action plan.

Track AI referral traffic (with a caveat).

PLATFORM	PASSES REFERRAL DATA?
Claude	Yes — tracks properly
ChatGPT	Search links yes; in-content links on paid accounts use no-referrer → invisible
Perplexity	Web yes, desktop app no
Copilot	Web yes, Windows no
Grok	No — passes nothing

TREAT ANALYTICS AS AN UNDERCOUNT / TREND

Set up: GA4 custom channel "AI traffic" (chatgpt.com · perplexity · gemini · copilot · claude.ai · deepseek) — or a privacy-friendly web analytics tool with a built-in AI channel.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Pillar 1 — AI referral traffic: when someone clicks from an AI platform and lands on you. But attribution is leaky: some platforms strip referral data so visits appear as "direct." ChatGPT's search-result links pass referral, but in-content links on paid accounts use a no-referrer attribute and vanish; Claude tracks properly; Perplexity tracks on web but not desktop; Copilot on web but not Windows; Grok passes nothing. Treat what you see as an undercount and a trend.

To set up in GA4, create a custom channel group isolating AI sources (regex for chatgpt.com, perplexity, gemini.google.com, copilot.microsoft.com, claude.ai, deepseek.com). Simpler still, some free web analytics tools have a built-in AI channel and separate "unknown" from "direct" traffic.

Bot analytics + self-reported attribution.

2 · AI bot activity

- Track crawlers, not humans — bots hit pages far more
- **Training bots** (GPTBot, Google-Extended) vs **citation bots** (ChatGPT-User, OAI-SearchBot — these drive referrals)
- Bot-traffic analytics via a Cloudflare integration (free plan works)

3 · Self-reported attribution

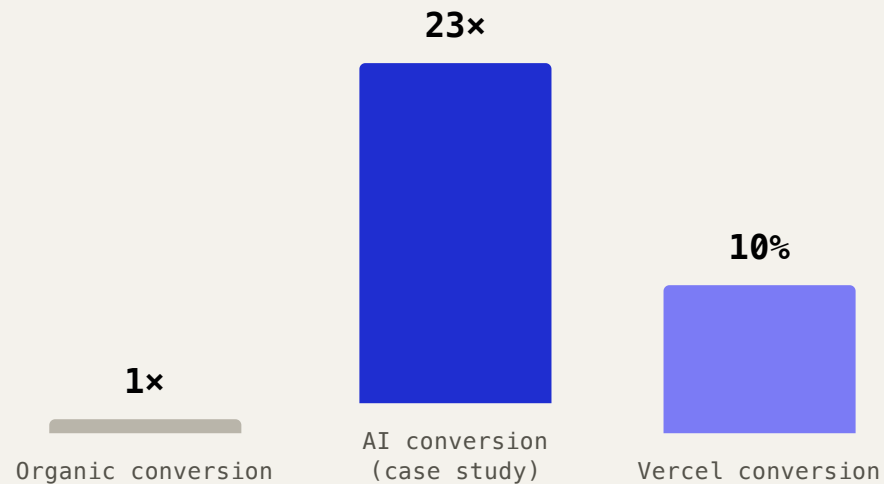
- Most AI impact never hits analytics (direct / branded search)
- Add "**How did you hear about us?**" with AI options
- ~**3%** of conversions came from AI in one dataset — converting far above organic
- If you do one thing — do this

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

Pillar 2 — AI bot activity: track the crawlers themselves, which hit your pages far more than humans, so the pages they hit most are your strongest citation candidates. Distinguish training bots (GPTBot, Google-Extended) from citation bots (ChatGPT-User, OAI-SearchBot) — the latter fetch pages in real time and drive referrals. Use a bot-traffic analytics tool via a Cloudflare integration (works on the free plan).

Pillar 3 — self-reported attribution is the simplest and maybe most important. Much AI impact never appears in analytics: someone hears your name from ChatGPT, then types it directly or Googles it. Ask — add "How did you hear about us?" to signup/checkout. In one dataset, about 3% of conversions came from AI by self-report, converting well above organic (source: Ahrefs research). The three pillars work best together.

Small traffic, exceptional quality.



AI VISITORS ARRIVE PRE-QUALIFIED · TALLY CREDITS AI WITH +\$1M ARR (SOURCE: AHREFS RESEARCH)

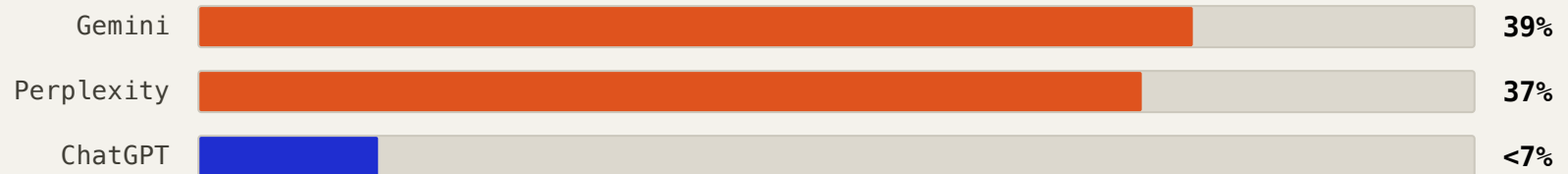
AI referral $\approx 0.25\%$ of traffic and Google sends $\sim 210\times$ more – but AI traffic grew $9.7\times$ YoY (ChatGPT +85% since January). The bigger prize is brand awareness inside the answer.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

On raw volume AEO looks small — AI referral is ~0.25% of total traffic, and Google still sends ~210× more than the top AI platforms combined. But quality flips the story: in one case study, AI visitors converted at 23× organic; Vercel sees 10% conversion from AI, and Tally calls AI its largest channel, crediting +\$1M ARR. Volume is growing fast — 9.7× year over year, ChatGPT +85% since January.

The bigger prize is brand awareness *inside* the AI conversation: every recommendation is an impression that often leads to a later branded search. AEO isn't an alternative to SEO — it's a new layer on top, and building it early is a durable advantage.

Measure progress — defend your facts.



FAKE-BRAND TEST · HOW OFTEN EACH REPEATED PLANTED MISINFORMATION

Track in your AI brand-visibility tool: **share of voice** · **cited domains** · **topic coverage** · **sentiment** (monthly check, quarterly deep audit). Fill every info gap with specific, official content — AI picks specific fiction over vague truth.

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Revisit the baseline you set in Module 2 and track four things in an AI brand-visibility tool: AI share of voice vs competitors, cited domains (new sites citing you), topic coverage (gaps closing), and mention sentiment. Do a quick monthly check and a deeper competitive audit quarterly.

A warning: AI is vulnerable to misinformation. In one controlled test (Ahrefs research), a fake brand was created, contradicting sources were planted across a blog, Reddit and Medium, and eight AI platforms were asked about it — Gemini and Perplexity repeated the false claims in 37–39% of answers, while ChatGPT stayed under 7% and cited the official FAQ 84% of the time. The defense: fill every information gap with specific, official content (a real FAQ with numbers, dates, facts) — because AI tends to pick specific fiction over vague truth. Monitor, and on finding errors publish contradicting content, then get the third-party source corrected.

Your AEO action plan.

THIS WEEK

- **1.** Check robots.txt for AI-bot access (~5 min)
- **2.** Set up AI analytics + "How did you hear about us?"
- **3.** Refresh your top 5–10 pages (real updates)
- **4.** Run your brand gap analysis in an AI visibility tool
- **5.** Identify your top 10 mention-earning targets

ONGOING

- Monthly AI-visibility check
- Quarterly competitive audit
- Rinse and repeat

■ EXPLANATION – FOOTNOTE

Bring it together. **This week:** (1) check robots.txt — five minutes, the most common blocker; (2) set up AI analytics and add "How did you hear about us?" so you measure from day one; (3) refresh your top 5–10 pages with meaningful updates; (4) run your brand gap analysis before optimizing; (5) identify your top 10 mention-earning targets via cited-domains and pages reports.

Ongoing: a monthly AI-visibility check and a quarterly competitive audit — then rinse and repeat. Every step maps back to a lesson.

Start before everyone else.

- **SEO is the foundation of AEO** — it builds on your work, it doesn't replace it.
- **Brand mentions are the strongest lever** (0.664) — earn them across editorial, community & your own channels.
- **Cover whole topics, not single keywords** — fan-out rewards breadth; freshness & format beat length.
- **Each platform is its own ecosystem** — prioritize by market share and SEO overlap.
- **Measure with three pillars** — referral, bot analytics, self-attribution — and defend your brand's facts.
- **The opportunity is early.** Small volume, exceptional conversion, fast growth — the biggest edge is starting first.

■ EXPLANATION — FOOTNOTE

To recap: SEO is the foundation AEO builds on; branded web mentions are the single strongest lever; you win by covering entire topics rather than single keywords, keeping content fresh and using cite-friendly formats; each AI platform is its own ecosystem to prioritize by market share and SEO overlap; and you measure with three complementary pillars while defending your brand's facts.

AI search is still early — the tools are evolving, the data is improving, and the opportunity is only growing. The biggest advantage you can have is simply starting before everyone else does. Thanks for taking the course.